



Digital Detective

How We Solved a \$10M Online Scam Using Smart Data

An interactive and easy-to-follow case study detailing how we cleaned messy police records, structured them into a secure relational directory, and traced threat actors globally.

Case Study by: Aditi Paitandy

Lead Systems & Data Pipeline Developer

The Real-Life Cyber Crime

Exploiting Trust Online

Imagine everyday people trying to register local family businesses or search for secure investment programs. They click on a seemingly official local directory and submit their contact forms.

Within hours, polished and polite "registration agents" contact them, requesting application fees. Once transfer transactions clear, the phone lines are cut and websites are deleted overnight.

This investigation traces an elusive cyber crime operation consisting of coordinate financial scams, phishing networks, and fake outlets that totaled over **\$10 million in direct losses**.

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"They seemed like legitimate government agents. They sent official receipts, signed letters, and verified license credentials. The moment our processing fee was wired, the platform dissolved entirely."

— CASE REPORT, CYBER CRIME UNIT

⚠ The Messy Evidence Room

50+

CHAOTIC UNSTRUCTURED LOGS

✖ Why Traditional Analysis Crashed

Investigators sat on over 50 disjointed spreadsheets and text documents cataloging incident profiles. Pattern detection was practically impossible due to extreme structural inconsistencies:

- AB ✓ **Spelling Variance:** Cities and suspect aliases spelled three different ways, preventing query aggregations.
- ✖ **Comma Crashes:** Description paragraphs contained text commas, causing standard database imports to break mid-row.

Cleaning the Chaos Step-by-Step

Instead of inspecting thousands of confusing rows manually, we engineered an automatic **"washing filter"** to parse, clean, and store reports cleanly. Think of it like sorting laundry!



Washing the Text

Polishing description text blocks, aligning formatting symbols, and containing nested commas so loading procedures don't crash.



Standardizing Inputs

Correcting spelling variations across city metrics, states, and event categories to enable pinpoint grouping later.



Secure Archival

Routing the newly filtered, highly optimized dataset directly into structured, normalized relational vaults.

The Smart Filing Cabinet

Filing with Absolute Cleanliness

In flat spreadsheets, if a single suspect carries out 10 distinct crimes, their full biography, phone number, and network details are typed 10 times. This creates duplication nightmares.

We resolved this structural issue using **Database Normalization**. Think of it like a smart office drawer setup where records are divided into clean, specialized folders linked by lightweight index cards:

-  **Folder 1 (Locations):** Isolated state profiles and warning ratings.
-  **Folder 2 (Suspects):** Hidden criminal aliases and group networks.
-  **Folder 3 (Cases):** Links incidents cleanly to the folders.


LOCATIONS




CORE CASES




SUSPECTS

Our Database Blueprint

As mapped in our MySQL Workbench directory, the system utilizes exactly six interlinked tables. This ensures zero data leakage and total relational integrity.

cyber_cases

- 🔑 case_id
- crime_type
- financial_loss_usd
- 🔗 location / suspect / victim [FK]

evidence

- 🔑 evidence_id
- file_hash_code
- forensic_status
- 🔗 case_id [FK]

investigators

- 🔑 investigator_id
- full_name
- specialization
- cases_assigned

locations

- 🔑 city_id
- city_name / state
- region
- risk_category

suspects

- 🔑 suspect_id
- alias
- known_affiliations
- arrest_status

victims

- 🔑 victim_id
- age / income
- compromise_index
- sector

What Did the Data Reveal?

Once the messy evidence records were systematically structured, the database immediately highlighted the most active types of crimes and financial damages.

 **Ransomware (Server Locks)**

\$250,000.00

 **Phishing (Fake Emails)**

\$45,000.00

 **Identity Theft (ID Frauds)**

\$32,000.00

 **Online Fraud (Fake Outlets)**

\$8,000.00

Takeaway: Ransomware attacks (locking critical company server records) yield the highest financial profit per crime event, but low-level fake outlet fraud holds the highest sheer frequency.

Finding the Fraud Hotspots

By grouping incident files according to localized metrics, the system cleanly calculated geographic densities and total losses.

City Name	State	Region	Cases Logged	Total Losses (USD)	Risk Category
Mumbai	Maharashtra	West	6 Cases	\$5,143,700.00	 CRITICAL
Bengaluru	Karnataka	South	6 Cases	\$385,500.00	 HIGH
Delhi	Delhi	North	6 Cases	\$677,000.00	 CRITICAL
Chennai	Tamil Nadu	South	6 Cases	\$1,164,500.00	 HIGH
Hyderabad	Telangana	South	6 Cases	\$753,500.00	 HIGH

Unmasking Repeat Offenders

Online attackers conceal their names behind burner SIM cards and falsified aliases. By linking records, we exposed key active threat networks.

Hacker Alias	Known Gang Affiliation	Skill Level	Current Status	Linked Cases	Calculated Damage (USD)
Shadow_Phisher	PhishKit Gang	Expert	 Arrested	6	\$798,500.00
DataVault_Breacher	APT-Shadow Group	Expert	At Large	5	\$5,674,000.00
CryptoLock_Raven	DarkByte Ransomware	Expert	At Large	5	\$1,526,500.00
QuickFlip_Scammer	Local Gang	Beginner	 Arrested	5	\$707,000.00
Cyber_Silhouette	Solo Operator	Beginner	 Arrested	5	\$344,000.00

Tactical Performance Leaderboard

We also audited and optimized internal case response units to balance assignments cleanly according to specialized success indicators.

Investigator Name	Rank	Specialization	Assigned	Solved	Success Rate (%)	Avg Resolution
DSP Ramakrishna Pillai	DSP	Critical Infrastructure	12	10	83.33%	 22 Days
Inspector Pooja Nambiar	Inspector	Identity Theft	15	12	80.00%	31 Days
ACP Arjun Verma	ACP	Financial Cybercrime	18	14	77.78%	28 Days
Inspector Suresh Babu	Inspector	Nation-State Threats	11	8	72.73%	45 Days
Sub-Inspector Preeti Sharma	Sub-Inspector	Crypto Crime	14	10	71.43%	33 Days

⚡ Finding Answers Instantly

📖 The Book Index Analogy

Imagine holding a dense, 500-page historical catalog of local fraud events. If you search for "Phishing Logs" by reading word-for-word, it takes days. This is a baseline database search without optimization.

Instead, you flip directly to the alphabetical ****Index**** at the back, find the term, and jump directly to page 41 and 188. It takes you 2 seconds.

By creating structured indices on heavily audited criteria like **Crime Type** and **Loss Values**, search operations dropped from slow milliseconds to instant lookups under full server loads.

🔍 Search Speed Improvements

Without indexing, the machine is forced to sweep every transaction row sequentially to locate matches.

NO INDEXING

❗ **Slow Scan**



WITH INDEXES

✅ **Microsecond**

Solving the Real-Life Scams



Freezing Bank Records

By connecting separate incident cards with specific transfer routing metrics, authorities can legal order banks to freeze scammers' asset holding pools immediately.



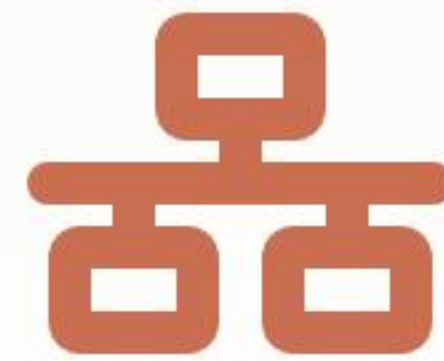
Ironclad Court Proof

Instead of disjointed, confusing logs, the unified directory maps timeline matches cleanly, demonstrating to court judges exactly who targeted which target systems.



Proactive Intervention

Now, the moment a new report matches a known suspect's phone list, warning locks are triggered, containing the scam's reach within minutes.



Let's Connect & Build!

Designed & Engineered by Aditi Paitandy

I build clean, optimized database designs, automated background pipelines, and humanized analytical tools. There are many more interactive codebases and structural portfolios on the way!



Explore My GitHub Repositories